It is December 1943, and the troopship Otranto is about to leave Liverpool, England, for Algiers. Boarding it is 20-year-old Jim Dixon of the Manchester regiment. He is on the first leg of a voyage to Italy. Jim is heading for the unknown, but seems unworried...

"... many jokes about swimming and camels. …The dickens of a job, lugging kit-bag and Tommy gun..."





Top: port of Liverpool, World War 2; Right: Jim Dixon; Left: City of Otranto, 1948

Dec 11 1943
… by truck to Monkseaton stn. Stuck around on the cold platform with full kit till about 11, then away. Some lads very gloomy, many jokes about swimming and camels.

Dec 12 1943
The usual fitful dozing till about 7. Arrived at the port [Later annotation: 'Liverpool'] about that time. By truck to the docks. The dickens of a job, lugging kit-bag and Tommy gun. Then, as usual, stood around an hour or two - pack weighing about 2 tons. Embarked just before dinner time. Packed like sardines down below, kit stuffed everywhere. [Later annotation: 'City of Otranto'.]

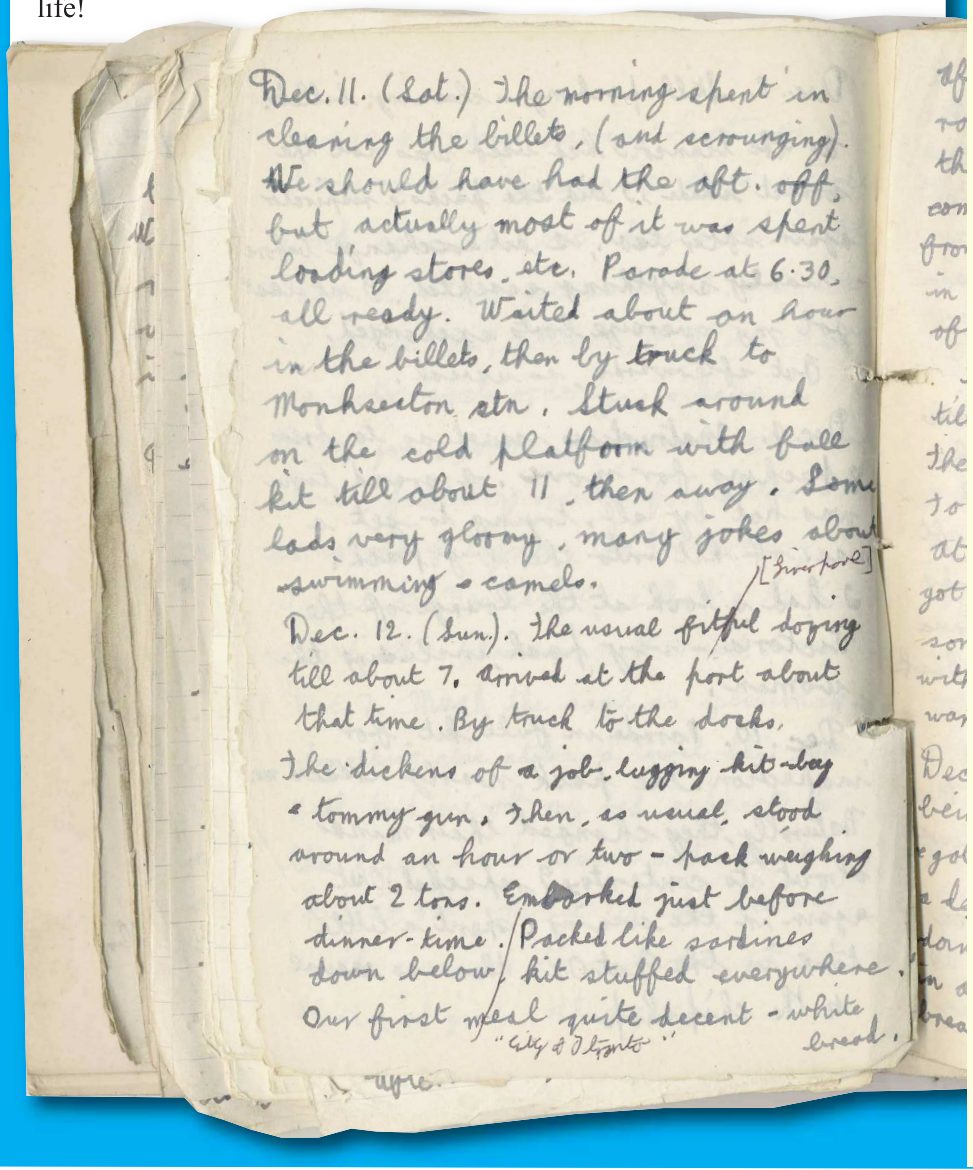
Our first meal quite decent – white bread. Afterwards we went on deck and wandered round the ship. … Back, and wrote my last letter from here. Mr Welsh got it sent off in the green envelope. Meals here come often, but aren't much. After tea I was bagged for fatigues, and worked till 11.30 on the dock, shifting cases. … to bed about 12, in my hammock. At first, when I got in, the clothes got out! Apart from us there are some of 'Stanley Cheetham's Corps', with nurses, civilians, an American war correspondent and ENSA. Quite a few women.

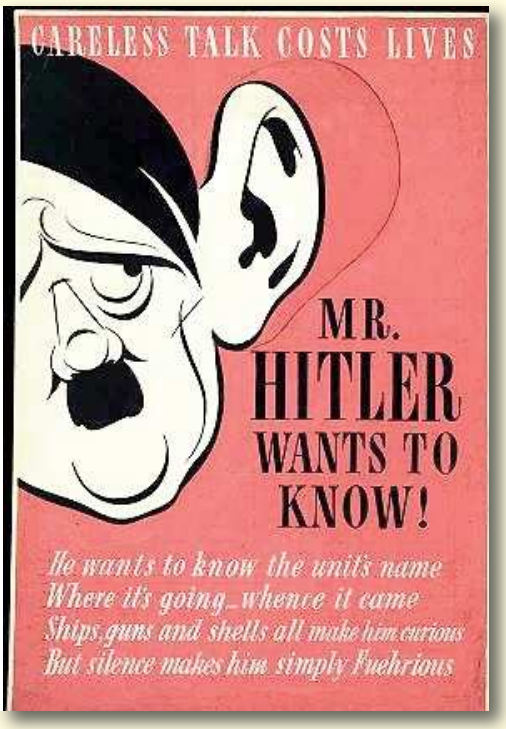
“Much weeping because smoking not allowed on troop decks ... rough water ... What a bloody life!”

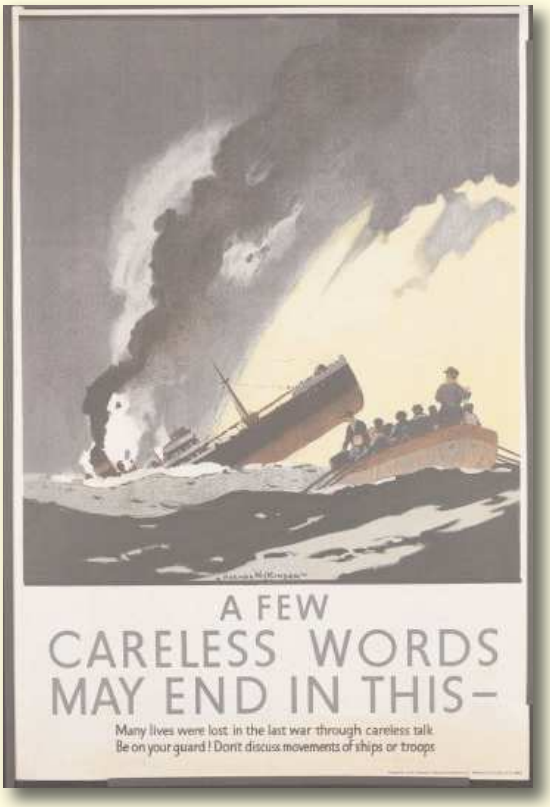
Dec 13 1943
What a night! The hammock being too short, I had to curl up and got cramp every hour. Up 6.30, … ‘emergency stns’ in aft. Dinner short, tea – 1 slice bread and marge, ½ mug tea. They made up for it at supper, corned beef, cheese and beetroot! We moved out about 12, and after dinner stood on the deck and watched the land disappear. My cards were in great demand all evening. Canteen still closed. I tried washing in salt water. Definitely no good.

Dec 14 1943
… Nothing to do all morning but roam the decks. A general knowledge quiz in the aft. [On **Dec 16** Jim reported: ‘I was officially informed that I had won the quiz 2 days ago, and awarded 5 shillings – considerable jealousy!’] Spare time filled in playing cards or draughts. After supper an ENSA show [Entertainments National Service Association - not Every Night Something Awful, as the joke went!], excellent, in the troop-deck. An issue of 200 cigs and 10 bars choc. per man …. Much weeping because smoking not allowed in troop-decks.

Dec 17 1943
When I awoke this morning the boat was in rough water, and rolling like a see-saw. Tattersall went down pronto. I managed to get some food down at breakfast, dinner and tea, but then a rash bar of chocolate finished me off. I was on deck in the morning – spray coming over the lower decks – but spent the rest of the day flat on my back below decks. What a bloody life!


Dec. 11. (Sat.) The morning spent in cleaning the billets, (and scourging). We should have had the aft. off, but actually most of it was spent loading stores etc. Parade at 6.30, all ready. Waited about an hour in the billets, then by truck to Monkseaton stn. Stuck around on the cold platform with full kit till about 11, then away. Some lads very gloomy, many jokes about swimming + camels. [Biscuits]
Dec. 12. (Sun). The usual fitful dozing till about 7, arrived at the port about that time. By truck to the docks. The dickens of a job lugging kit-bag + tommy gun. Then, as usual, stood around an hour or two – pack weighing about 2 tons. Embarked just before dinner-time. Packed like sardines down below, kit stuffed everywhere. Our first meal quite decent – white bread.
"City of Otranto"





The diary page that took 60 years to be completed

The names ‘Liverpool’ and ‘City of Otranto’ have plainly been added at a later date, in ballpoint pen. The reason for the omission of military and shipping details is almost certainly the fear induced by posters like those above. Since the diaries were found next to Jim’s work desk after his death (in 2005), it seems likely he added these in his final years.

The late comedian Spike Milligan’s memoirs mention that he, too, sailed on the Otranto - in January 1943. Like Jim, he also went on to fight in Italy. His experiences are hilariously recounted, the first book in the series being, ‘Adolf Hitler: my part in his downfall’. Though first published some forty years ago, they are still available.

“The ship rolled like a bastard, carrying part of the rail away”

Dec 18 (Sat) 1943
A night as bad as the day before. At 8 they put me on guard. I never thought it possible, but I did it. I was aft on E deck – cold, but fresh air, so I survived. Tattersall seemed to be dying, but they put him on guard about tea-time. The sgt. let me off the 2 A.M. shift. My sea legs gradually being acquired.

Dec 19 1943
I seem to have caught something or other. In the morning I went on deck, but was perpetually shivering ...

Dec 20 1943
... I missed the M.O., and had to go up to the hospital. I waited there 4 hours, then saw him. To my surprise, he put me in dock [hospital] right away. I stayed in bed all day – very comfortable after a troop-deck…

Dec 23 1943
My temperature down this morning, so when the M.O. came round he turned me out. I don’t seem to have missed much…

Dec 24 1943
We passed through the Straits [of Gibraltar] about mid-day. We could see the coast on either hand – big rock masses to the N. We handed all our sterling money in…

Dec 25 (Xmas Day) 1943
Sailing up the coast all morning – very rocky. Sing-song in aft., then a service. Decent dinner – no turkey, but plum duff. Reached port [Algiers] in the early aft., and docked. Rushed all kit on, and the usual hectic scramble to disembark. Eventually landed. Then we marched in battle order about an hour through the docks – it creased me. … Reached camp about 11… Acres of mud and tents. Put on guard ...



Reggio, September 3 1943 (Operation Baytown): troops of the York and Lancaster regiment on board a ship travelling to the Italian mainland

(photo from Imperial War Museum)

Dec 26 1943
…This is a queer place – you eat your meals in the open, no tables or seats. Hawkers with oranges, but we aren’t supposed to buy from them. Lavatories - holes in the ground. ...

Dec 31 1943
... Off to the town after tea.... Was with two other M/Cs, and a French civilian bought us wine. A party of French sailors there – very jolly and musical – celebrating the New Year, I suppose. Funny, I hadn’t realised it was New Year’s Eve till someone reminded me. What an end to the year!

1944

Jan 1 1944
Rain in the morning, drowned half the tent. Fortunately my kit kept dry. Pay after dinner – about time. With such quantities of notes, I felt quite rich....

Jan 5 1944 [voyage to Sicily]
Reveille 4.30. Messed around in the dark, at last all packed up. [Algiers] Moved off in open trucks to the port … On board our ship [a French light cruiser, Jeanne d’Arc], spread ourselves, our kit and blankets on the decks - packed like sardines. Had tea, then settled down to sleep. Meanwhile, the ship moved out, and began rocking. First spray over the side, then waves. I stuck it till a wave flooded the deck, then went into the crew’s quarters and slept there, in my greatcoat on the floor.

Jan 6 1944
What a mess! The decks awash from the waves, some kit overboard, all soaked. All mine there, but wet. We gathered the blankets up to be dried. The ship rolled like a bastard, carrying part of the rail away. ...

Jan 8 1944
Came into harbour [Syracuse] just after breakfast. Got our kit together and disembarked. Marched to the barracks in FSMO [full service marching order] and greatcoats that made us sweat. Good quarters, though, the first proper barracks I have ever been in. We got our kit hung out to dry, spread the blankets out in the courtyard. Then I stripped my Tommy gun - what a mess. … No lights in the barracks, blankets still wet – what a night! [An Italian army barracks, Caserma Gaetano Abela]





Above: troop deck scene by Edward Ardizzone;
Right: 'At sea - soldiers playing cards in a bunk', November 1941, by Ronald Searle. (Pictures by Imperial War Museum)

Italy's fascist leader Benito Mussolini allied with Hitler in June 1940. After defeating German and Italian forces in North Africa, British and American troops invaded Sicily on 10 July 1943.In part due to this, Italian leaders deposed Mussolini on July 25 1943 and arrested him. He was rescued from prison in a daring raid by German special forces, and set up as a puppet leader heading the Italian Social Republic.

The new Italian government announced an armistice with the allies on 8 September. German troops then occupied Italian towns and cities, and disarmed Italian forces.Mainland Italy was invaded by allied forces in September 1943 - some at Salerno, below Naples. However, it still remained to take Rome.



Mussolini and Hitler, Monaco 1938



Left: troops queue for a mug of tea at an Egyptian port while waiting to embark on ships bound for Sicily, 12 July 1943.

(Dry land must presumably have come as quite a relief after the troopship experience with its seasickness, boredom and cramped conditions.)

Jan 9 (Sun) 1944
... Allowed out after dinner. I went out with Pete Young and Queen, a Scots lad … a few glasses of Marsala, and hunted for a cinema – generally had a look around. Not a bad place – a bit dilapidated in parts by bombs or something. Not a bad day either.

[Jim's time in Sicily was spent partly in training such as bayonet fighting and gun-drill - though on one occasion Italians stole their targets for firewood! There were other duties, such as guarding prisoners. But Jim found time for learning Italian - and for fun.]



British troops during Operation Husky in the streets of Pachino, Sicily, summer 1943. (The fighting in Sicily was over when Jim arrived.)

"We drove up the foot of Italy ... high hills, fine scenery, and blown up bridges"

Jan 23 (Sunday) 1944
...Today the Festa of San Sebastian, I saw the statue being carried ... In the evening went to the NAAFI talent competition – Ken Moores sang.

Jan 28 1944
...Out in the evening to the State Theatre. … Inlying piquet turn – out to look for escaped janker-wallahs [soldiers on punishment], poor sods …

March 22 1944
...Three drunken sailors were thrown out, and left a bottle of Marsala. I grabbed it, then to Casa Spadiro, arrived back blindo. ...

April 1 1944
... Great flap on because of escape of 5 prisoners yesterday, and shooting and stabbing in town. Inlying piquet called out as sentries.

[On **March 29** Jim and 6 others were transferred to a mortar company, and just a few days later they made the crossing to mainland Italy.]



Children begging for biscuits from British soldiers at Canosa di Apuglia, Italy, 1943. Water colour (Imperial War Museum) by Edward Ardizzone. (Similar scene to the one Jim's describes on right.)

April 5 1944
Reveille 3.45 – they woke us about 4.30! One hurried rush to get our kit to the trucks and get our breakfasts. … Straight down to the docks and on to the train-ferry. … Only a short crossing over the Straits, drove off and we were in Italy. Both Reggio and Messina looked like the Moors. We drove N. along the coast, passing Scylla – a rock, not a monster. Steep cliffs all the way to Gioia Tauro. Arrived mid-day. Got our bivvies down, the first time I have seen them – all right too. ... Now allowed out at night.

April 6 1944
Reveille 4.30. Away 7.15. We drove up the foot of Italy 70 m to Severia - arriving about 2. Again high hills, fine scenery, and blown up bridges. Round Nicolastro [Nicastro?] we wound round and up the ravines like a circular staircase. Dust all the way, ... Snow on the roadside on the high ground. On guard at night, not fair. No inspection, though, and bags of grub.

April 7 1944
…. We camped at Spezzano Albani. The village was out of bounds, so Gill and I tried to find a farm. Unsuccessful, so Taffy Williams and I found a village called S. Lorenzo. I got some sweet lemons, and was offered a fowl, e.g. sucking pig. We went to a wine shop, and for 1/6 got 1½ pints of red wine – arrived back totally merry.

April 9 1944
...Still thousands of kids yelling for cigarettes and biscuits. Bags of bully and biscuits, and oranges that a Yank gave us. Arrived at Canosa after 3 ...

“Saw abandoned British and German tanks near Termoli, many graves”

April 11 1944
Up to a temporary camp about 30 m from the enemy lines across the Trigno. Good weather, rough roads. Saw abandoned British and German tanks near Termoli, many graves. [the Battle of Termoli was won by the 8th Army in October 1943, according to 8th Army records.] Arrived about 12, bivouacked in field. … Expect to be in action this week.

April 12 1944
... Pay at night – 200 lire each man and NAAFI rations. … The cooks put salt in the tea instead of sugar, so no tea! Bread, though, instead of our usual biscuits. Got all my kit sorted out in the dark, and packed it ready for action. Got some mail.

April 14 1944
A strange experience – I was dreaming, but fully aware of it and able to choose my dream! … Moved after lunch, to 7 m. from the front line, bivvied in a wood. Bags of ammo carrying all day, hot too. In the evening went out with Spencer, tried to walk to [Lanciano], but found it too far. Talked with some Indian troops, and came back.

April 15 1944
Packed up again, and moved off to front. Waited a bit in town, bought sweets – everything seemed normal. 9 of us packed in truck, with equipment and kit!



A 4.2-inch mortar of the British 1st Infantry Brigade’s support group, firing in support of the 5th Northamptonshire Regiment in the Anzio bridgehead, 18 May 1944 (IWM)



Wrecked German Tiger 1 heavy tank near Rome, 18 June 1944 (Source: German Federal Archive)

Reached positions, 2,500 yds from front. Mounted mortar, spent remainder of day digging in bivvies. Hot sun, hard work. Shellfire over our heads. Dug pit too narrow, like sleeping in a ditch.

April 18 1944
Our whole section moved several miles along the line. ... On guard at night, no inspection. Williams and I together. Great watchfulness.

April 20 1944
Dropped a real clanger. I was trying to empty my rifle magazine for inspection and put a bullet through my small pack, water bottle, holdall and breech cover! On a charge. We dug a slit trench and a tunnel to the mortar pit. Went to Lanciano for baths ....

“Jerry sent some back and shook us. Cpl. Etches got in so quickly he knocked a sandbag down on me”

April 21 1944
Pay and NAAFI rations. A bottle of beer each – soon gone. Finished off our tunnel, got our mortar in. Fired three bombs, all OK. … Jerry sent some back and shook us. Cpl. Etches got in so quickly he knocked a sandbag down on me. Still very hot. ...

April 22 1944
Heavy rain all day. We fired in the morning. OK. The rain brought our bivouac down, flooded the pit and drowned our kit. We had to shift it all to open ground. I got wet through and covered with mud to the thighs, like a snowman. On guard at night, slept in my greatcoat in a tarpaulin, still wet through. Now I can imagine what Flanders was like.

"wrung out socks, emptied boots ... Rain still pouring"

April 25 1944
Again a row with [Lt.] Rowberry over 'cleanliness on parade'. That charge over my shot has been dropped, though. We fired heavily and successfully all day and evening. The C.O. paid us a visit after dinner. I spent the aft. in the pit getting mud off my B.D. Guard in the evening, first turn, cushy. Slept outside, rain in the night, wet blankets, dived inside tarpaulin.

April 27 1944
Woke about 2 AM, found tent had fallen in and about 2 inches of water in pit. Spent rest of night sitting on respirator to keep dry. At dawn wrung out socks, emptied boots and crawled out. Found sides had caved in, blankets totally under mud. Rain still pouring. Got all out, soaked. Later they installed us in a barn. Cpl. Brewer lent me gym pants – heaven! Mortar pits flooded and collapsed. ..

April 29 1944 (Sat)
Moved down from the barn to our old bivvies, which we are to remain in, the new area being flooded. Began protecting our mortars with earth-filled ammo tins. After dinner fired from temporary positions on the road, then straight back. On guard at night with Taffy, first turn again, cushy. Plenty of sleep.



Two artillerymen wringing water out of a blanket after heavy rain at their flooded bivouac on Mount Camino during the advance to the Gustav line in December 1943. (Photo from Imperial War Museum.)

"Rowberry threw grenades - all kinds of a flap on"

May 2 1944
... On guard at night with Taffy. … Very nervy, though – Taffy nearly shot a firefly!

May 5 1944
On a wiring party, putting a fence round the camp ... I took my shirt off to start a sun-tan course ... went to the YMCA, then to see an ENSA show - great. ...

May 7 1944
Completed the fencing of the camp.Also went up to the OP [observation post] with rations. ... Shelling just above the camp about 3, very near, rather shook us. Distribution of papers and comforts.

May 9 1944
Strung empty shell cases on our lovely fence – it shows up like Blackpool tower. ... Blanco, khaki green, arrived with our NAAFI rations. The most disgusting bullshit [polish] this year. On guard with Dick.

May 11 1944
Off to the rest camp at B'Echelon with Dick Gill [pictured in the Gothic Line section] and Cpl. Hallows. Richardson was to have come, but was checked for a rusty bayonet. ...

May 12 1944
...To Lanciano after dinner, had a bath. The laundry at last had some underpants in. ....To the Regent cinema, saw 'Ziegfeld girl', quite good entertainment. ...

May 14 (Sun) 1944
Our days of rest were over, so we left about 9.30. We soon heard heavy gun-fire which continued till long after midnight. We called on 5 section first, and found they had been firing since 5 O'clock. Ours had been up too, had had one whole night standing by in the pits in our absence. … fired in the evening. News and signs of heavy activity on our front. Odd bombs shook us, esp. Dick going to the OP. On guard with Dick, 3rd turn. All called out about 12, Cpl. Flavell and others having fired at something that rattled our [wire?]. Rowberry threw grenades - all kinds of a flap on. …

May 16 1944
Helped Cpl. Flynn as malaria contoller, spraying Flit around...

May 18 1944
... wrote to Eric. Am getting a nice brown now. On guard at night. Reveille at 4, so not much sleep.Cassino taken.

"Several air-bursts fired over us. Cpl. Hallows was slightly hit"

May 19 1944
Today we exchanged positions with Sherwood's lot. Definitely a bad bargain. Up at 4, moved early. …I ran up and down the cliff like a goat. Rowberry very pally. We have our bivvy on the ground – light rain but it stopped. ... Cpl Linnet said the OP was worse, corpses. What a game.

May 21 1944
As before. Bags of shit flying at the OP, so communications difficult. ... On guard, a shoot about 9.30 P.M..

May 22 1944
Still cheesed off with this job, all day taken up running up and down the hill all the time. A (Jerry?) plane came over in the evening and dropped 4 flares, lighting us up. Several air-bursts fired over us. Cpl. Hallows was slightly hit in the ankle by shrapnel. Fired several times during the evening and night.



A 3-inch mortar crew of no. 2771 Field Squadron RAF Regiment bombarding enemy positions from their position in a ravine on the Colle Belvedere, north of Cassino. (Picture from Imperial War Museum)

May 26 1944
Not much sleep that night - we fired twice at 1 and 3. ... Our Anzio and Cassino troops joined up.

May 28 (Sun) 1944
… We fired about 20 bombs about 7 O'clock – 2 misfires! I never met one before, and I certainly had the wind up when I had to lift the barrel out. OK though...



Men of 1st Duke of Wellington's Regiment march into Rome, 8th June 1944. (Imperial War Museum)

May 30 1944
The horse flies have been biting me like the devil. … Saw one of our battn. trucks shelled to bits a mile down the road we take! Moving tomorrow again.

May 31 1944
We moved again ... Taffy got badly bitten by a land crab, and then saw a snake, so we hastily evacuated the guard room.

June 2 1944
...Excitement in 3 (Cpl. Flynn), a misfire, then the secondaries exploded and set fire to the prepared ammo and cam. net! Poor old unlucky Taffy hurt his hand. ... (written by moonlight)...

June 3 1944
We moved again, some miles nearer the coast. ... Damned good positions ready, a big dug-out by the mortar pit, large enough for us all to sleep in. Plenty of work so far ...

June 4 (Sunday) 1944
…We fired about 40 bombs in the aft and evening ... A high Eytie officer came round, smashing uniform, bags of decorations pinned on it, similar Goering. One of the Eytie civilians helped us carry bombs up!

June 5 1944
… the enemy mortared Poggia [poss. means Foggia?], on our route. Poor old Taffy was there, but O.K. During the aft., our mortar fired continuously, about 50 bombs. ...Confirmation that Rome has fallen. [Rome fell to the allies on June 4 1944]



Above:'Too hot to sleep' by Frank Ward, 1943 - British soldiers play cards in a tent.
(Both pictures from Imperial war Museum)



Above: YMCA tea car 'in action', Anzio bridgehead, May 1944

In June Jim was away from the front line, training in the summer heat. Thank goodness for NAAFI and YMCA canteen vans! (Jim records on **July 9:** '...When the YMCA van came round, some of us were in a photo taken of it....') The lads had other consolations too, such as:

June 6 1944
News that the second front [Normandy landings] has opened. Very relieved and glad. On ammo fatigues again in the morning, bringing stuff from 5 and 3 section's old positions. Very hard work. ... Fired twice late on.Bagnall missing, but turned up. ....

June 7 1944
... glad to be out of the line. All moved back to B Echelon safely [on **June 13:** 'We moved to join the rest of the Bn. at Casali. ... Day found us a position half way up a mountain...']

June 17 1944
Reveille 2 AM. Stumbled with our kit in the dark down that damned cliff – only 10 of us on parade at 4 – and Rowberry went off the deep end. He was going to put 23 of us on a charge! Set off 5 AM. Hot most of the way, one heavy shower. Arrived at Ielsi about 6...

June 18 (Sun) 1944
We spent the whole day working on the tracks up to the camp, digging ruts and filling them with stones. Rowberry had a childish fit and made us work till about 9 PM. Several heavy showers and general dampness. What a young puppy he is!

"then they found the river bed was mined!"

June 29 1944
On a scheme. We moved off at night to beyond Gambatesa. ...We had a long carry of 200 – 300 yds up a river bed – the tripod nearly creased me, and it was unnecessary too. We set the mortars up and did some 'firing', then they found the river bed was mined! …

June 30 1944
... Damned hot, but the NAAFI van came. ... Off at 4 PM on a night scheme. We halted at a farm for dinner and Baggy [Bagnall?] bagged a cockerel, but Rowberry made him throw it away. ... Back about 3, then went on guard, got 1 hour's sleep.

July 10 1944
... 14 pln were firing their mortars on the range ….. A fire started, and 5 of us went to put it out. Just as they neared it, they dropped an H. E bomb about 40 yds from me. ...

July 19 1944
Up at 4, and a damned poor breakfast. Set off about 7, covered a good 70 miles. We came through Isernia, the worst bombed place I have yet been in, also Venafro. ...

June 10 1944
... Late at night we had a 'concert', one of our new acquisitions has a guitar, and we spent about an hour singing all the old songs.

June 22 1944
…Housey-housey after dinner, but I won nowt.

June 24 1944
...Housey-housey again, won (getting better)!...

July 1 1944
...Thorley was in a state and Bagnall was paralytic when we got back, he wandered all over the field, and Cpl. Linnett carried him to his tent.

July 7 1944 : ...I went to an open air film show at B.H.Q., "Hit parade of 1943", jolly good too.



"We went through the centre of Cassino, a shattered ruin of a town"

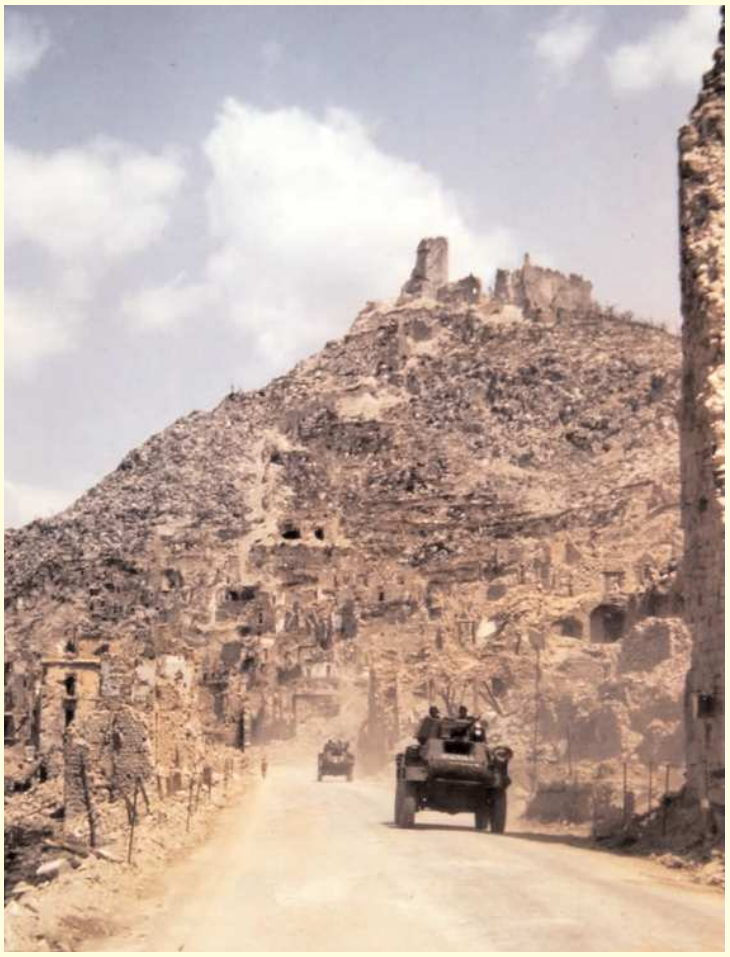
July 20 1944

Up at 3 … We went through the centre of Cassino, a shattered ruin of a town. Every house was down and the blocked streams had made a swamp of it. All but the road was wired off because of booby-traps. All the area was full of great bomb and shell holes, with many graves. During the journey we saw many smashed German tanks, some guns and very many burnt-out trucks. We halted for a minute outside the Hotel des Roses, a thick-walled building. [See below.]

The monastery on its bare hill was shattered, and so was every house for miles around. We also came down the Liri valley, through Arce (not too bad), and to Valmontone, outside which we had lunch. It was as bad as Isernia, the people seemed all to be living in caves. A lot of fruit offered for sale, many refugees. Little damage then till our camp, about 11 miles from Rome. We settled in comfortably, though I dropped for cutting sandwiches. The area we saw today has certainly had hell.

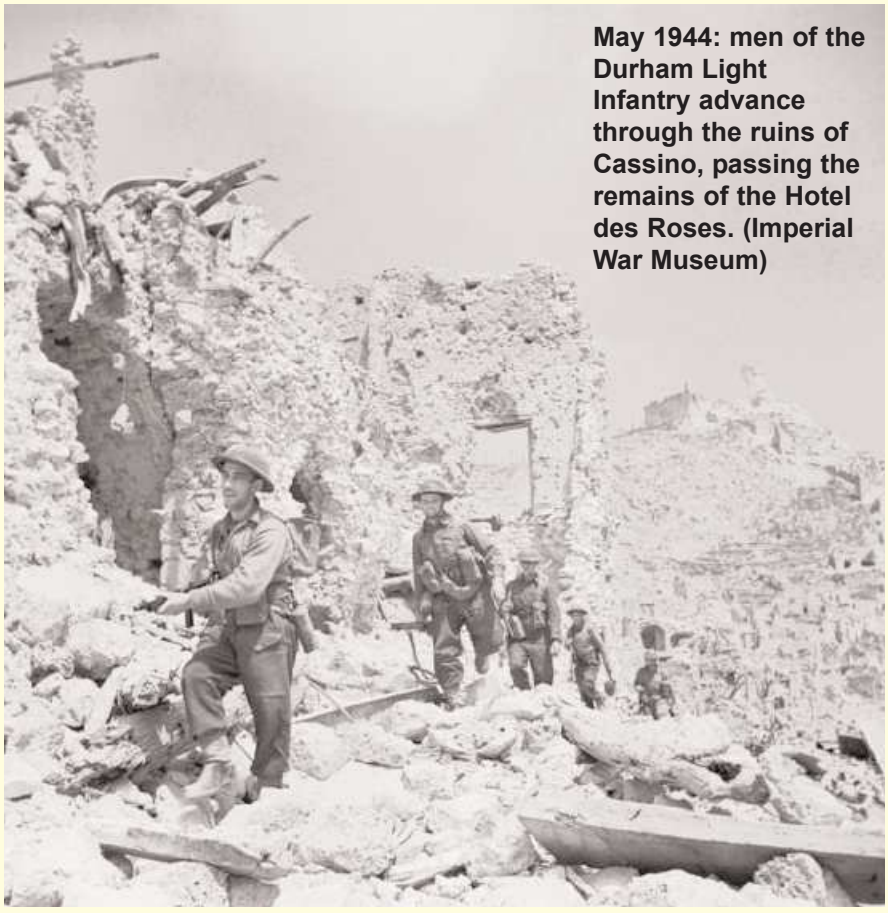
July 21 1944

…We belted on through Rome, so did not get a chance to see much. It seemed a decent city – many large blocks of flats, plenty of shops etc. We saw little of the well known part, though – one decorated church, a Roman aqueduct and the Olympic stadium. We saw the Tiber and as we left the city glimpsed the dome of St. Peters. After that we went up the Perugia road to beyond Narni, then turned off to somewhere near Foligno, making 101 miles altogether. Almost entirely open upland country, little sign of warfare except demolished bridges. We made our camp in a field, as usual, quite a decent spot, though isolated. On guard, but only did an hour.





Above: British tanks rumble past the ruins of Cassino on the way to the front.



May 1944: men of the Durham Light Infantry advance through the ruins of Cassino, passing the remains of the Hotel des Roses. (Imperial War Museum)



Right: Albrecht Kesselring (1885 - 1960), Commander of all German forces in Italy from November 1943. Captured in Austria in May 1945, he was found guilty of the massacre of 320 Italian prisoners.

German General Albrecht Kesselring withdrew his forces to the Gustav Line on the Italian peninsula south of Rome. It included Monte Cassino, a hilltop site of an ancient Benedictine monastery. The allies suffered terrible losses trying to capture it. In January 1944, General Dwight D. Eisenhower and British General Harold Alexander, Supreme Allied Commander in Italy, ordered a new Cassino offensive.The monastery was destroyed by bombs in February 1944. However, this turned out to be of tactical benefit to the Germans, who occupied the ruins and used them for defensive cover.

Eventually, on May 18 1944, Monte Cassino was captured. This enabled allied troops to reach the port of Anzio, and the German defence began to disintegrate. Rome was liberated on June 4. Then the allies were held up on the Gothic Line in the northern Apennines.

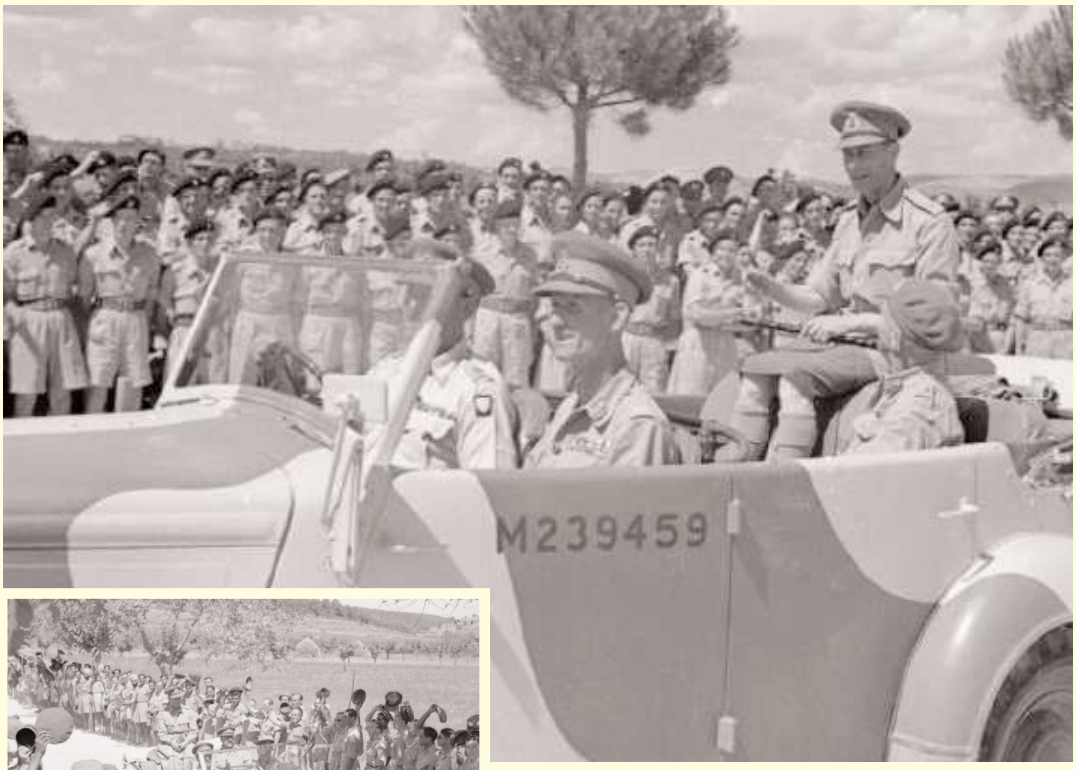
"We lined the road... I got a glimpse of the King"

July 25 1944
Reveille at 4.45 – for a parade at 14.45! We were told on parade that we were to see the King, General Alexander and General Leese. … We went in the 3-tonners to Perugia air-field, then several miles east. We got to a field about 9, and stayed there till 3, baking. They had a 'rehearsal', and messed us around and gave orders for 'organised cheering' when the King arrived.

We lined the road, then the convoy drove past at about 8 MPH. I got a glimpse of the King, though he was bending over talking to the aides. I didn't get the time to pick out anyone else. We set off back, but were held up, first by another convoy and then one of our own trucks. Arrived back about 8 – 15 hours messing about for 1 minute's glimpse – everyone cheesed off with the whole affair!

Another training period followed. Jim grew bored - and mischievous:

July 27 1944
Another idiotic day – cleaning the outside of the trucks. We didn't kill ourselves. I rather took the piss out of Rowberry on parade, and he reacted sharply. At last NAAFI rations and mail ...





Above: HM King George VI and generals Leese and McCreery, being driven past troops after landing at Perugia, 25 July 1944. (Jim possibly in the crowd.)
Left inset: July 26, the King on his way to knight General Sir Oliver Leese in the field and invest Sepoy Kamal Ram with the Victoria Cross for his bravery on the Gustav Line.

August 1 1944
Off early for field firing with the brigadier to watch us. We did it as a scheme, all very pukka. Unfortunately, they said the bombs landed in the wrong spot, and Rowberry dropped a terrific clanger. Instead of coming back for tiffin [lunch] we stayed out and fired again – 10 hours without a meal. Even then they weren't satisfied. Major Gill slanged us, and Rowberry and Major Robinson looked as if they were ready to burst into tears. Cpl Etches flapped as well, in fact it was a very happy party. ...

August 4 1944
Another hour of alleged work after dinner, then I had a bath – in my tin hat! An Eytie girl walked through the field at the wrong moment, but I said San fairy Ann.

August 5 1944
An interesting morning, learning how to load mortars onto mules! I felt sorry for the one with the base-plate.

August 9 1944
... the platoon went to D Coy [Company] HQ for a company 'do'. We had a quiz in which our team won, and I distinguished myself. Prize, 40 cigs and a toothbrush. Then we had tea, cakes and poco vino...

August 13 (Sunday) 1944
… In the evening C Coy had a vino do. Sgt. Ravenscroft paid for vino for our pln. They set out to make me drunk - and filled my mug 11 times - but I poured a lot out unobserved! All the same I got thoroughly drunk.

August 18 1944
... Smashing news from France, nearing Paris. ...



'Three-inch mortar sections' by Edward Ardizzone resembles Jim's tale of August 1. Soldiers stand firing a mortar, watched by 3 officers to the right. In front a soldier reviews their target through binoculars.

Pictures from the Imperial War Museum

August 21 1944
... I was rather lucky and spent the morning preparing food, not cleaning dixies. Bags of preparations for moving. Just before dinner, Rowberry caught me 'urinating in the hedge', and whipped me on a charge. As I was finishing my dinner ... Sgt. Major Davis said I was on orders in 25 min! Bob [Major, I think] said 'admonished', with the usual additions. That little episode saved me from cleaning the dixies up. ...

Jim, my father, makes many references to Lieutenant Rowberry - largely unflattering. Rowberry's charge against Jim of 'urinating in the hedge' (left) certainly seems bizarre. (Is getting caught short in shrubbery really against Army regulations?) Perhaps it was his idea of making the punishment fit the crime - since, as Jim admitted on **July 27:** 'I rather took the piss out of Rowberry on parade.'

Another amusing point is that the army loved keeping soldiers occupied with quizzes, which my father invariably won - the prize usually being cigarettes. His general knowledge obsession must have kept him in Woodbines through much of the war!

Janet

"getting closer to Jerry. Found German newspapers etc. …Just as we were getting the kit down he opened up with mortars"

August 22 1944
Reveille half an hour earlier, for no obvious valid reason, except the old army custom. … Moved off at 9, side lights only. It was a dark night, and hell for the drivers. The trailers obscured the rear-lights, and trucks kept hitting the trailers in front. People got lost, and all kinds of things went wrong… [Several days travel - calling at Sassoferrato - follow.]

August 25 1944
... Packed up, all ready by evening. Some rotten blighter stole my water bottle cork, but I improvised one. Moved off about 11... The truck had enough buckshee kit on board for an officers mess - even the shit-house in the trailer! ...

August 27 (Sun) 1944
Off at 8.30, and travelled till mid-day. One incident, when Major Bob took the wrong track. Passed two German prisoners, and the usual odd damaged vehicles. The Eyties were digging up the possessions they had buried. Occasional big guns firing, otherwise NTR [Nothing to report]. Played Housey and read all aft.

August 28 1944
… . I went to an Eytie house to beg a cork, and got quite friendly. Later I was invited in, to talk to a French girl. She was pretty, from near Paris, and I talked with her about half an hour … We moved forward during the aft, getting closer to Jerry. Found German newspapers etc. Got into position in the early evening. Just as we were getting the kit down, he opened up with mortars for about half an hour. A bit of shrapnel bounced off Dick's gaiter. In bravado, I finished preparing some bombs, then joined the rest in digging in.

...though we were on the alert most of the night, did not fire. Every Eytie we meet says that Jerry took away all the clothes, food etc., he could find. They hate him. He certainly had me bomb-happy. The two carriers were nearly blown up, all bashed about. Laidlaw (DR) accidentally injured. Rowberry left him by the roadside. Bitten all evening by mosquitoes.

August 29 1944
…. This time we took up position on an open moor. Bedded in, then settled down to wait. We are actually firing on the Gothic Line… Got our slit trenches dug. Intermittent shelling all over the place, but not on us, though Gray said shrapnel took some skin off his nose. I wrote a letter. Great trouble over water, but managed. Many tanks passed – envious. Also saw our planes dive-bombing Jerry, saw the bombs dropping… Tea and turkey for supper.



German mortar crew training, C 1934 - 39 (Federal archives)

Jim was with a mortar platoon. A mortar is a tube into which a shell (called a bomb or round) is dropped. When it reaches the base of the tube it hits a firing pin which detonates its propellant and fires the shell.

Its arc-like, lobbing trajectory means it can drop shells behind obstacles. Another advantage is that mortars and their ammunition are generally smaller and lighter than other artillery. However, it operates well at short range, but not long.

August 30 1944
Did nothing all morning, but read papers (Union Jack, 8th Army News, Sunday Chronicle). Shelling distant. After lunch went to a well for water. Route in view of enemy. Lots of shit flying round. Well bucket U/S [unserviceable]. Rowberry sent us back after an hour, no water. Nice view of Gothic Line. Rowberry seemed nervy. As before, we all did a stag. I slept in my slit trench - quite comfortable.